PSYCHOLOGICAL/COGNITIVE FALSE BELIEF #41 · ANXIETY

# “Something terrible is about to happen.”

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## Where it often comes from

Anxiety is a body alarm that learned to ring early. A scare, a loss, a parent who always expected the worst, or a season of real danger can teach the mind to treat a quiet moment as the pause before disaster. The alarm feels like information. It is often a habit of predicting the worst before anything has happened.

## What Scripture teaches

God does not tell His people that nothing hard will ever happen. He tells them not to live as if disaster is already in the room. “Do not fear, for I am with you.” When the psalmist is afraid, he puts his trust in God. God is a refuge and an ever-present help. Courage is commanded because the Lord is with His people wherever they go. Tomorrow’s trouble is not today’s assignment. A feeling that something terrible is about to happen is not the same thing as it happening.

> *“Do not fear, for I am with you; do not be afraid, for I am your God. I will strengthen you; I will surely help you; I will uphold you with My right hand of righteousness”* (Isaiah 41:10).

## Also see

> “When I am afraid, I put my trust in You” (Psalm 56:3).

> “God is our refuge and strength, an ever-present help in times of trouble” (Psalm 46:1).

> “Have I not commanded you to be strong and courageous? Do not be afraid; do not be discouraged, for the LORD your God is with you wherever you go” (Joshua 1:9).

> “Therefore do not worry about tomorrow, for tomorrow will worry about itself. Today has enough trouble of its own” (Matthew 6:34).

## Common self-statements

- I can feel it. Something awful is next.
- If I relax, that is when it will hit.
- My dread has always been right.
- Other people are naïve. I see what is coming.
- I should cancel the plan so I stay safe.
- Peace would be careless.

## Common logical errors

- Fortune telling: Treating a dread as a report about the future.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling alarmed and concluding that danger is present.
- Catastrophizing: Jumping from a worry to the worst possible ending.
- Overgeneralization: Because something bad happened once, it is about to happen again.

## Challenging questions

- What, exactly, do I think is about to happen?

- What evidence do I have, apart from the feeling?
- How many times has this same dread been wrong?
- What would I tell a friend who felt certain disaster was next?
- What does God promise about being with me, not about a trouble-free day?
- What is one ordinary thing I can do while I wait to see what is actually true?

## Truth summary

> A feeling that something terrible is coming is not proof that it is. God is with me, and I can live this day without living in the catastrophe.

## Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Anxiety/Worry
- Fear
- Trust
- Peace
- God, All Powerful

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Anxiety/Worry/Fear
- Thinking, Healthy
- Trouble/Hardship

## What does a mentally healthy Christian look like?



Cover of Christlike: Walking the Walk, The Mentally Healthy Christian, by Dr. Brian Campbell with Rev. Jim Angelakos

From *Christlike: Walking the Walk* by Dr. Brian Campbell. A portrait, verse by verse, of how a mentally healthy Christian thinks, feels, and lives.

Read excerpts from "The Mentally Healthy Christian" (with every Scripture written out)

## Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

## Listen: Overcoming Depression

Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

## Songs that speak truth to this belief

**Fear Is a Liar** — Zach Williams
Fear makes up disasters. It is not a reliable reporter.

**Whom Shall I Fear** — Chris Tomlin
God's presence is the answer to "what if the worst is next."

**Battle Belongs** — Phil Wickham
You can hand the imagined catastrophe to God instead of rehearsing it.

**Turn Your Eyes Upon Jesus** — Reawaken Hymns
Look at Christ, who is with you, rather than at the disaster you are inventing.

*Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, what is one step I could take today?"*

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

# My Plan for Replacing "Something terrible is about to happen."

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

## 1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

*Rate it now so you can see your progress later.*

"Something terrible is about to happen." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

## 2 My best question

*The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.*

- ☐ What, exactly, do I think is about to happen?
- ☐ What evidence do I have, apart from the feeling?
- ☐ How many times has this same dread been wrong?
- ☐ What would I tell a friend who felt certain disaster was next?
- ☐ What does God promise about being with me, not about a trouble-free day?
- ☐ What is one ordinary thing I can do while I wait to see what is actually true?

My own question: _____

## 3 My replacement truth

*The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.*

- ☐ A feeling that something terrible is coming is not proof that it is. God is with me, and I can live this day without living in the catastrophe.
- ☐ This alarm is a feeling, not a news report.
- ☐ God is with me in the day I actually have.
- ☐ I can be afraid and still put my trust in God.
- ☐ I do not have to solve tomorrow before tonight.
- ☐ Most of the disasters I rehearse do not arrive.

In my own words: _____

## 4 My Scripture

*The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.*

- ☐ Isaiah 41:10
  *"Do not fear, for I am with you; do not be afraid, for I am your God. I will strengthen you; I will surely help you; I will uphold you with My right hand of righteousness."*
- ☐ Psalm 56:3
  *"When I am afraid, I put my trust in You."*
- ☐ Psalm 46:1
  *"God is our refuge and strength, an ever-present help in times of trouble."*

A verse I found myself: _____

# Practicing the Truth

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## 5 My practice plan

*Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.*

### EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

### PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] When the "something terrible" feeling came: Each day, write down one moment when disaster felt moments away. Write what happened, what you told yourself, and one more accurate statement.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  *For example, Isaiah 41:10 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I feel afraid, and God is with me. This feeling is not a disaster.""*
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Fear" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio or the Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

## 6 My action step this week

*Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.*

*Choose steps you can do safely. If this belief comes with hopelessness or thoughts of ending your life, call or text 988 (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or call 911 in an emergency. You do not have to carry this alone.*

- [ ] Name the prediction. Write the disaster you expect, then write what you actually know. Cross out anything that is only a feeling.
- [ ] Check the record. List three times this same alarm was loud and the feared event did not happen.
- [ ] Stay for one ordinary plan. Keep one small commitment you feel like canceling, and write what actually occurred.
- [ ] Pray Isaiah 41:10 when the alarm starts, before you rearrange your day around it.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

## 7 End-of-week check-in

*Bring this page to your next session.*

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Something terrible is about to happen.": _____ %  My truth: _____ %

## Daily practice tracker

| Day | Read my card | Said my verse | Used my reminder | A dread that did not come true |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Mon | | | | |
| Tue | | | | |
| Wed | | | | |
| Thu | | | | |
| Fri | | | | |
| Sat | | | | |
| Sun | | | | |

## My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

| Day | Song I listened to | What it told me that challenges the lie |
|---|---|---|
| Mon | | |
| Tue | | |
| Wed | | |
| Thu | | |
| Fri | | |
| Sat | | |
| Sun | | |

## My Truth Card

**THE LIE**

~~Something terrible is about to happen~~

**THE TRUTH**

**GOD'S WORD**

*Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.*

## Prayer

*Lord, my body is sure that disaster is next. Teach me to trust You with this day, and not to bow to a feeling as if it were a fact. Amen.*

*Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.*